DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Can Evil Ever Destroy Good Completely?

Daat Tevunot §130-132

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §130-132
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 5 June 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap and the new part

So far in Section 6 we have seen the three levels of Adam before and after the sin (part 1), and that all destruction comes from a lack of connection between the parts of creation (part 2). This class covers part 3, "good is never totally destroyed", and opens part 4.

Hashem never meant evil to last

The Sekhel says (§130) that before explaining how Hashem removes evil, we need one preface. Hashem allowed destruction and bad, but He never meant them to last forever. Their purpose is that everything will in the end be rectified. So He decreed that destruction never wipes anything out completely. A remnant, a trace of good, always remains, and from it the thing can be healed "like a sick person who recovers".

The Rabbi put it simply: the bad is not there to annihilate but to corrupt. It makes things less good, but something good always remains, and from that the good returns.

Death and the luz bone

The strongest example is death, the greatest destruction there is. Even then the body does not disappear entirely. The luz bone, which the Rabbi described as a small bone near the neck, remains, and from it the body will be rebuilt at tehiyat hametim. Resurrection will not use new bodies but the same ones: "your own bones Hashem will revive".

The Ramhal explains this through the parallel between man and the world. The body comes from the darkness of hester and the soul from the light that gives life. When Hashem withdraws His light, the body decays. But a tiny drop of light stays even in the darkness of the grave, so the body never decomposes completely and the soul is never entirely cut off from it.

Participants asked whether the luz is what we would now call DNA. The Rabbi said some have suggested this, but not everything one reads is agreed by everyone. On those who were cremated in the Holocaust, he said the luz is the hardest thing to destroy and the last thing to be destroyed.

Israel in exile and the seed

The second example is Israel. The Ramhal quotes the verses that even when Israel are trampled to the dust and subjugated by their enemies, Hashem will never reject them completely. A remnant always remains. The Rabbi noted that these lines were written long before the Holocaust.

The idea behind all of this, the Rabbi explained, is that Hashem does not regret what He has created and does not reject it outright. He does not push it away "with two hands" and let destruction take over. He lets His creatures suffer for a time, which in the end is for their good, and then they flower again, "like the earth brings forth its growth and like a garden makes its seeds sprout".

The best proof, says the Ramhal, is the seed. It rots in the ground, but it does not vanish. It sprouts again. The Rabbi called this the key message for hard times: "just like the seed has to decompose, has to go through difficult times, but ultimately it sprouts again." He said this is not just a hope. It is the reality.

He brought the Maharal's point that galah (exile) and gaal (redemption) share almost the same letters. On a simple level, light is appreciated more after darkness. On a deeper level, following the Ramhal, the redemption actually grows out of the exile. This is why Tahanun is not said on Tisha BeAv. The usual reason is that the redemption will come on that day, but according to this it fits even better. Within the saddest day there is light, so we cry in the morning and are also happy, because from the crying the good will sprout.

The Rabbi linked this to what was learned in the previous section. Bad comes about through Hashem withdrawing, which is why His name is not placed on it. Yet nothing can exist unless Hashem wants it to, so He is still "hovering over" even the bad, and wherever He is, something good must remain.

Burial and the tunnels

A side discussion arose about the teaching that the dead will roll through tunnels to Eres Yisrael at the resurrection. The Rabbi understood it as a refinement process, the body being refined again by the soul, which may involve some pain. He questioned the common practice of flying bodies to Israel for burial. Many poskim hold that it is not right to bring tumah into the land, and the advantage of being buried there lies in the kedushah of the land, not in having "less distance to travel".

Part 4: how evil is rectified

The class then began part 4 (§132): how is the world rectified? Footnote 83 in the English edition explains that Hashem wanted the right balance of good and evil so that man could have free choice. In the first stage, the divine emanation was allowed to be dimmed, which let evil come into being. In the second stage the aim was the opposite, to hold the evil back so that it does not take over.

The Rabbi explained that this is what hester panim means. The flow that comes down is imperfect, and that is real bad, not an illusion. But nothing can exist without some flow, just as

a dimmed light is still on. If the switch were turned off completely, nothing would remain. The plan was to finish part 4 and Section 6 on Thursday.

Summary

- Hashem never intended destruction to be permanent. A trace of good always remains, from which things can be rebuilt.
- Even death leaves the luz bone, from which the same body will be raised at tehiyat hametim.
- Israel in exile, like a seed in the ground, are never destroyed completely and will sprout again.
- Galah and gaal are bound together, and that is why there is light even on Tisha BeAv.
- Part 4 begins: a first emanation was dimmed to allow evil, and a second one holds evil in check.

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